

RELEASING SHAME

A Guided Workbook for Healing

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You are worthy of belonging.

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UNDERSTANDING SHAME VS GUILT

GUILT says: 'I did something bad.'

SHAME says: 'I AM bad.'

Guilt is about behavior. Shame is about identity.

Guilt can be productive - it motivates us to change.

Shame is NEVER productive - it keeps us stuck.

Where shame comes from:

- Family messages ('You're too much', 'You'll never be enough')
- Cultural/religious messages about worthiness
- Trauma and abuse (making us feel fundamentally broken)
- Perfectionism (anything less than perfect = failure = shame)
- Comparison and social media

MY SHAME MESSAGES:

What shame tells me about myself:

Where I first learned this message:

SHAME TRIGGERS INVENTORY

Shame is triggered in specific areas. Rate each 1-10:

Appearance/body	____/10
Intelligence/competence	____/10
Parenting	____/10
Work/career performance	____/10
Sexuality/intimacy	____/10
Money/financial status	____/10
Being a good friend/partner	____/10
Mental health	____/10
Addiction/habits	____/10
Aging	____/10
Relationships/belonging	____/10
Motherhood/fatherhood	____/10
Religion/spirituality	____/10
Being seen/vulnerability	____/10

My top 3 shame triggers:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

THE SHAME SPIRAL

Shame creates a downward spiral. Recognizing it is the first step out.

THE CYCLE:

1. TRIGGER: Something happens (criticism, failure, rejection)
2. PHYSICAL: Body responds (face flush, chest tight, stomach drop)
3. THOUGHT: 'I'm not enough' / 'Something is wrong with me'
4. EMOTION: Shame floods in (feels like drowning)
5. BEHAVIOR: Hide, withdraw, lash out, numb, or overachieve
6. ISOLATION: Shame thrives in secrecy and silence
7. REINFORCEMENT: Isolation confirms 'I don't belong'

INTERRUPTING THE SPIRAL:

- Name it: 'I'm feeling shame right now.'
- Share it: Tell one safe person.
- Normalize it: 'Everyone feels this sometimes.'
- Self-compassion: 'I'm human. This is part of being human.'

MY SHAME SPIRAL:

My trigger: _____

My body signal: _____

My shame thought: _____

My typical behavior: _____

How I can interrupt: _____

SHAME RESILIENCE

(Based on Brene Brown's Research)

Shame resilience is the ability to move through shame without losing yourself.

THE FOUR ELEMENTS:

1. Recognizing Shame

Know your physical symptoms, triggers, and messages

2. Critical Awareness

Reality-check the expectations causing your shame

3. Reaching Out

Share your story with someone who has earned the right to hear it

4. Speaking Shame

Name it. Shame cannot survive being spoken aloud

MY SHAME RESILIENCE PLAN:

I recognize shame in my body by: _____

The expectation I need to reality-check: _____

Safe person I can reach out to: _____

How I will speak my shame: _____

CRITICAL INNER VOICE IDENTIFICATION

The shame voice often sounds like someone from our past.

Whose voice is your inner critic? _____

COMMON SHAME VOICE MESSAGES:

- ☐ 'You're not good enough'
- ☐ 'Who do you think you are?'
- ☐ 'You don't deserve good things'
- ☐ 'Everyone can see you're a fraud'
- ☐ 'You're too much/not enough'
- ☐ 'You'll never change'

MY inner critic says:

REWRITING THE VOICE (what is actually TRUE?):

Critic says: _____ Truth: _____

Critic says: _____ Truth: _____

Critic says: _____ Truth: _____

Critic says: _____ Truth: _____

REWRITING SHAME NARRATIVES - 1

THE SHAME STORY:

What happened (just the facts):

What shame told me it meant about me:

THE REWRITE:

What actually happened (with compassion):

What is TRUE about me:

What would I say to a friend in this situation?

My new narrative (one sentence):

REWRITING SHAME NARRATIVES - 2

THE SHAME STORY:

What happened (just the facts):

What shame told me it meant about me:

THE REWRITE:

What actually happened (with compassion):

What is TRUE about me:

What would I say to a friend in this situation?

My new narrative (one sentence):

REWRITING SHAME NARRATIVES - 3

THE SHAME STORY:

What happened (just the facts):

What shame told me it meant about me:

THE REWRITE:

What actually happened (with compassion):

What is TRUE about me:

What would I say to a friend in this situation?

My new narrative (one sentence):

REWRITING SHAME NARRATIVES - 4

THE SHAME STORY:

What happened (just the facts):

What shame told me it meant about me:

THE REWRITE:

What actually happened (with compassion):

What is TRUE about me:

What would I say to a friend in this situation?

My new narrative (one sentence):

REWRITING SHAME NARRATIVES - 5

THE SHAME STORY:

What happened (just the facts):

What shame told me it meant about me:

THE REWRITE:

What actually happened (with compassion):

What is TRUE about me:

What would I say to a friend in this situation?

My new narrative (one sentence):

SELF-COMPASSION EXERCISES

(Based on Kristin Neff's Research)

THREE COMPONENTS OF SELF-COMPASSION:

1. Self-Kindness

Treating yourself as you'd treat a good friend

2. Common Humanity

Remembering suffering is part of being human

3. Mindfulness

Acknowledging pain without over-identifying with it

SELF-COMPASSION BREAK (use in moments of shame):

1. 'This is a moment of suffering.' (mindfulness)
2. 'Suffering is part of life.' (common humanity)
3. Place hand on heart. 'May I be kind to myself.' (self-kindness)

PRACTICE: Write yourself a compassionate letter:

VULNERABILITY PRACTICE

Vulnerability is the antidote to shame. It requires courage.

Vulnerability is NOT oversharing. It IS showing up authentically.

VULNERABILITY LADDER (start small, build up):

Level 1: Share a preference or opinion

Level 2: Ask for help with something small

Level 3: Admit you don't know something

Level 4: Share a feeling in the moment

Level 5: Set a boundary

Level 6: Share something you're struggling with

Level 7: Apologize without excuses

Level 8: Let someone see you imperfect

MY VULNERABILITY PRACTICE THIS WEEK:

What I'll do: _____

With whom: _____

What I'm afraid will happen: _____

What actually happened: _____

WORTHINESS AFFIRMATIONS

Read these daily. Say them out loud. Write the ones that resonate:

I am worthy of love and belonging.

I am enough, exactly as I am.

My worth is not based on my productivity.

I deserve to take up space.

My past does not define my worthiness.

I am allowed to make mistakes.

I belong here.

I am worthy of connection.

My imperfections make me human, not broken.

I choose to believe I am enough today.

My personal worthiness statement:

SHAME IN RELATIONSHIPS

Shame shows up in how we connect (or disconnect) with others.

SHAME-DRIVEN RELATIONSHIP PATTERNS:

People-pleasing:	Abandoning yourself to be accepted
Perfectionism:	Never letting others see the real you
Withdrawal:	Pulling away before others can reject you
Aggression:	Pushing others away before they get too close
Over-giving:	Earning your right to exist through service

My pattern: _____

How shame shows up in my closest relationship:

What I really need from others:

BODY SHAME HEALING

Body shame is one of the most common and devastating forms of shame.

Messages I received about my body growing up:

What I want to tell my body now:

Things my body does for me (gratitude):

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

My body neutrality/appreciation statement:

SHAME AWARENESS LOG - WEEK 1

Mon	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Tue	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Wed	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Thu	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Fri	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Sat	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Sun	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N

Pattern I notice: _____

Self-compassion practice: _____

Connection I made: _____

SHAME AWARENESS LOG - WEEK 2

Mon	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Tue	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Wed	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Thu	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
------------	----------------	------------------	-----------------	---------------

Fri	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
------------	----------------	------------------	-----------------	---------------

Sat	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
------------	----------------	------------------	-----------------	---------------

Sun	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Pattern I notice: _____

Self-compassion practice: _____

Connection I made: _____

SHAME AWARENESS LOG - WEEK 3

Mon	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Tue	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
------------	----------------	------------------	-----------------	---------------

Wed	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Thu	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Fri	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Sat	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
------------	----------------	------------------	-----------------	---------------

Sun	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Pattern I notice: _____

Self-compassion practice: _____

Connection I made: _____

SHAME AWARENESS LOG - WEEK 4

Mon	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Tue	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Wed	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
------------	----------------	------------------	-----------------	---------------

Thu	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
------------	----------------	------------------	-----------------	---------------

Fri	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
------------	----------------	------------------	-----------------	---------------

Sat	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
------------	----------------	------------------	-----------------	---------------

Sun	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
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Pattern I notice: _____

Self-compassion practice: _____

Connection I made: _____

SHAME AWARENESS LOG - WEEK 5

Mon	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Tue	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Wed	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Thu	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Fri	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Sat	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N
Sun	Trigger: _____	Intensity: __/10	Response: _____	Spoke it? Y/N

Pattern I notice: _____

Self-compassion practice: _____

Connection I made: _____

I AM ENOUGH DECLARATION

I AM ENOUGH.

Not when I achieve more.

Not when I lose weight.

Not when I earn more.

Not when I'm perfect.

Right now. As I am.

I AM ENOUGH.

